

Asthma

What is Asthma?

Asthma is a chronic lung disease that causes inflammation and narrowing of the airways, making breathing difficult. It is characterized by recurring episodes of wheezing, breathlessness, and coughing.

Triggers include allergens (dust, pollen, pet dander), air pollution, exercise, cold air, smoke, and respiratory infections.

Symptoms

Common symptoms: wheezing (whistling sound when breathing), chest tightness, shortness of breath, persistent cough especially at night or early morning.

Severe attack signs: very rapid breathing, inability to complete sentences, blue lips or fingernails (cyanosis), no improvement after inhaler use — this is a medical emergency.

Medicines

Short-acting bronchodilators (salbutamol/albuterol) are rescue inhalers that quickly relax airway muscles during an attack.

Inhaled corticosteroids (budesonide, beclomethasone) are controller medicines taken daily to reduce airway inflammation.

Long-acting beta-agonists (salmeterol, formoterol) are used with inhaled steroids for long-term control.

Montelukast (Singulair) is an oral leukotriene modifier for mild persistent asthma.

Oral corticosteroids (prednisolone) are used for severe flare-ups under medical supervision.

Emergency Actions

During an attack: sit the patient upright. Give 4-8 puffs of reliever inhaler (salbutamol) every 20 minutes.

If no improvement in 20 minutes or breathing is severely labored, call 112/911 immediately.

In a hospital setting, nebulized bronchodilators, oxygen, and IV corticosteroids are used.

Do not leave someone with a severe attack alone.

What You Should Do

Identify and avoid your personal asthma triggers. Use air purifiers if needed.

Take controller medications daily even when feeling well. Never stop without doctor advice.

Always carry your rescue inhaler. Know how to use a spacer device for better delivery.

Follow your Asthma Action Plan — a written plan from your doctor for managing symptoms.

Get the flu vaccine annually. Manage stress and maintain a healthy weight.